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REFRIGERANT MANIFOLD

Abstract

The present invention relates to a refrigerant manifold applied to a cooling module applied to a vehicle cooling system. According to the refrigerant manifold of the present invention, by forming a hole or a slit in a middle plate and a housing of parts to which in/out ports are connected or parts to which in/out pipes are connected to discharge a leaked fluid to the outside when leakage occurs inside a manifold, it is possible to increase the accuracy of a leakage test.

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Background/Summary

CROSS REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATION

[0001] The present application claims priority to Korean Patent Application No. 10-2024-0033037, filed Mar. 8, 2024, the entire contents of which is incorporated herein for all purposes by this reference.

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

Field of the Invention

[0002] The present invention relates to a refrigerant manifold applied to a cooling module applied to a vehicle cooling system.

Description of the Related Art

[0003] Recently, as interest in energy efficiency and environmental pollution issues has increased day by day, the development of eco-friendly vehicles capable of practically replacing internal combustion engine vehicles has been demanded, and such eco-friendly vehicles are usually classified as electric vehicles driven by fuel cells or electricity, and hybrid electric vehicles driven by an engine and a battery.

[0004] Among these eco-friendly vehicles, electric vehicles or hybrid electric vehicles do not use a separate heater unlike air conditioning devices in general vehicles, and the air conditioning system applied to the eco-friendly vehicles is usually called a heat pump system.

[0005] Meanwhile, in the case of the electric vehicles, a driving force is generated by converting chemical reaction energy of oxygen and hydrogen into electric energy, and during such a process, heat energy is generated by a chemical reaction in the fuel cell, and thus it is essential to effectively remove the generated heat to secure the performance of the fuel cell.

[0006] In addition, in the hybrid electric vehicles, along with the engine operated by a general fuel, the fuel cells or electricity supplied from electric batteries are used to drive a motor to generate a driving force, and thus the performance of the motor can be secured only when the heat generated from the fuel cells or the batteries and the motor is effectively removed.

[0007] Accordingly, a cooling system, a heat pump system, and a battery cooling system are formed in conventional hybrid electric vehicles or electric vehicles. Accordingly, a refrigerant manifold is used to reduce the size and weight of the cooling module and simplify the layout of pipes connecting a plurality of heat exchangers and a plurality of valves.

[0008] The refrigerant manifold is formed in a structure in which a first housing, a middle plate, and a second housing are stacked and joined by brazing or a structure in which only the first housing and the middle plate are stacked and joined, and thus even when there is no problem in the result of evaluating refrigerant manifold leakage, there is a concern that internal leakage may occur between the first housing and the middle plate or between the second housing and the middle plate.

[0009] In particular, there is a problem that, when internal leakage occurs at a part in which heat exchanger in/out ports formed in the first housing are connected and a part in which the heat exchanger in/out pipes formed in the second housing are connected, it is highly likely that leakage is not detected during leakage evaluation, and when this is applied to an actual product, there is a high possibility that the leakage affects A/C performance, H/P performance, and battery performance.

Related Art Document

[0010] (Patent Document 1) Korean Laid-Open Patent No. 10-2022-0162479 (entitled "INTEGRATED COOLING MODULE")

SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

[0011] The present invention has been made in efforts to solve the above problems and is directed to providing a refrigerant manifold, in which a hole or a slit may be formed in a middle plate and a housing of parts to which in/out ports are connected or parts to which in/out pipes are connected to discharge a leaked fluid to the outside when leakage occurs inside a manifold, thereby increasing the accuracy of a leakage test.

[0012] To solve the above problem, a refrigerant manifold according to one embodiment of the present invention includes a first housing in which a first refrigerant channel is formed on one surface thereof and a component mounting portion on which a component is mounted is formed on the other surface, and a middle plate stacked on one surface of the first housing to cover and block the first refrigerant channel, wherein the middle plate includes a first leakage detection portion formed at a position corresponding to the component mounting portion of the first housing to discharge a fluid leaking from the first housing to the outside of a space formed by the first housing and the middle plate.

[0013] In addition, the component mounting portion includes a fluid outlet hole that transfers a fluid toward the component, and a fluid inlet hole that receives the fluid from the component and is formed at a position spaced a predetermined distance from the fluid outlet hole, and the first leakage detection portion includes a slit formed to pass through an area between the fluid outlet hole and the fluid inlet hole.

[0014] In addition, the component mounting portion includes a bolt fastening portion formed between the fluid outlet hole and the fluid inlet hole and including a hole or a groove into which a bolt is inserted to be fastened to the middle plate, the middle plate has each through hole formed at a position corresponding to the bolt fastening portion, and the slit is formed to connect the through holes.

[0015] In addition, the component mounting portion includes the fluid outlet hole that transfers the fluid toward the component, the fluid inlet hole that receives the fluid from the component and is formed at a position spaced a predetermined distance from the fluid outlet hole, and a bolt fastening portion formed between the fluid outlet hole and the fluid inlet hole and including a hole or a groove into which a bolt is inserted to be fastened to the middle plate, the first leakage detection portion includes a plate-shaped first cover provided at a position corresponding to the fluid outlet hole and coupled to the component mounting portion, and a plate-shaped second cover provided at a position corresponding to the fluid inlet hole and coupled to the component mounting portion, and the first cover and the second cover are formed of separate components and provided at positions spaced a predetermined distance from each other.

[0016] In addition, the first leakage detection portion further includes a plate-shaped third cover formed of a component separately from the first cover and the second cover, provided at a position corresponding to the bolt fastening portion, and coupled to the component mounting portion.

[0017] In addition, the third cover is a flat plate formed integrally with the component mounting portion or attached to one surface of the component mounting portion.

[0018] In addition, a thickness of the third cover is greater than a thickness of the first cover or the second cover.

[0019] In addition, a thickness of the third cover is greater than an average thickness of the middle plate.

[0020] A refrigerant manifold according to one embodiment of the present invention includes a first housing in which a first refrigerant channel is formed on one surface thereof and a component mounting portion on which a component is mounted is formed on the other surface, a middle plate stacked on one surface of the first housing to cover and block the first refrigerant channel, and a second housing in which a second refrigerant channel is formed on the other surface thereof and which is stacked on one surface of the middle plate, wherein the second housing includes a second leakage detection portion formed at a position at which it is in contact with the second refrigerant channel to discharge a fluid leaking from the second housing to the outside of a space formed by the second housing and the middle plate.

[0021] In addition, the second refrigerant channel is formed as two or more second refrigerant channels in the second housing, the second refrigerant channels each extend in the same direction and are formed to be spaced a predetermined distance from each other, and the second leakage detection portion includes a first leakage hole formed between the second refrigerant channels.

[0022] In addition, the first leakage hole is formed as two or more first leakage holes in an extension direction of the second refrigerant channel.

[0023] In addition, the second refrigerant channel includes at least one bent portion at which the extension direction changes, and the first leakage hole is formed at a position at which it is in contact with the bent portion of the second refrigerant channel.

[0024] In addition, the middle plate includes a second leakage hole formed to pass therethrough at a position corresponding to the first leakage hole.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0025] FIG. **1** is an exploded perspective view illustrating a refrigerant manifold of the present invention.

[0026] FIG. **2** is a perspective view illustrating the entire refrigerant manifold of the present invention.

[0027] FIG. **3** is a partial perspective view illustrating a component mounting portion of the present invention.

[0028] FIG. **4** is a plan view illustrating a first leakage detection portion according to a first embodiment of the present invention.

[0029] FIG. **5** is a schematic view illustrating the first leakage detection portion according to the first embodiment of the present invention.

[0030] FIG. **6** is a plan view illustrating a first leakage detection portion according to a second embodiment of the present invention.

[0031] FIG. **7** is a schematic view illustrating the second leakage detection portion according to the second embodiment of the present invention.

[0032] FIG. **8** is a perspective view illustrating the entire refrigerant manifold of the present invention.

[0033] FIG. **9** is a plan view illustrating a second leakage detection portion of the present invention.

[0034] FIG. **10** is a schematic view illustrating the second leakage detection portion of the present invention.

[0035] FIG. **11** is a schematic view illustrating the second leakage detection portion according to one embodiment of the present invention.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF THE INVENTION

[0036] Hereinafter, the technical spirit of the present invention will be described in more detail with reference to the accompanying drawings. The terms or words used in the present specification and claims are not to be narrowly interpreted according to their general or dictionary meanings and should be interpreted as having meanings and concepts that are consistent with the technical idea of the present disclosure on the basis of the principle that an inventor can be his/her own lexicographer to appropriately define concepts of terms to describe his/her invention in the best way.

[0037] Hereinafter, a refrigerant manifold **1000** according to a first embodiment of the present invention will be described with reference to FIGS. **1** to **3**.

[0038] As illustrated in FIG. **1**, the present invention may include a first housing **100** and a middle plate **200**. More specifically, the first housing **100** is one of components coupled to the middle plate **200** to form a refrigerant flow path through which refrigerant flows, a plurality of first refrigerant channels **110** through which refrigerant flows may be concavely formed on one surface of the first housing **100**, and one or more component mounting portions **120** on which components are mounted may be formed on the other surface of the first housing **100**. In this case, the component is

a target component coupled to the first housing **100** and may be a heat exchanger that uses refrigerant flowing in the cooling channel of the first housing **100**. Here, the heat exchanger may be any type of heat exchanger. For example, the heat exchanger may be a water-cooled condenser, a chiller, and the like. In addition, the component may be any component.

[0039] In addition, the middle plate **200** may be formed in a flat plate shape and stacked on one surface of the first housing **100** to cover and block the first refrigerant channels **110**. In this case, as illustrates in FIG. 2, the middle plate **200** may include a first leakage detection portion **210** formed at a position corresponding to the component mounting portion **120** of the first housing **100** to discharge a fluid leaking from the first housing **100** to the outside of the first refrigerant channels **110**, more specifically, to the outside of the component mounting portion **120**.

[0040] By including the first leakage detection portion **210**, the refrigerant manifold **1000** according to the first embodiment of the present invention may discharge the leaked refrigerant to the outside through the first leakage detection portion **210** even when refrigerant leaks between the first housing **100** and the middle plate **200**, that is, therein, thereby more smoothly checking whether leakage occurs when a leakage test is performed on the refrigerant manifold **1000** of the present invention.

[0041] In addition, as illustrated in FIG. 3, the component mounting portion **120** may have a shape that protrudes from a curved shape of the other surface of the first housing **100**, and a surface of the component mounting portion **120** to which the component is coupled may be formed flat. In addition, the component mounting portion **120** may include a fluid outlet hole **121** that transfers a fluid toward the component and a fluid inlet hole **122** that receives a fluid from the component and is formed at a position spaced a predetermined distance from the fluid outlet hole **121**. In addition, the component mounting portion **120** may include a bolt fastening portion **123** that is formed between the fluid outlet hole **121** and the fluid inlet hole **122** and includes a hole or a groove into which a bolt is inserted to be fastened to the middle plate **200**.

[0042] Since the component mounting portion **120** includes the bolt fastening portion **123**, the middle plate **200** and the first housing **100** may be fixed. In this case, a head portion of the bolt fastened to the bolt fastening portion **123** may be fastened to press the first housing **100** without pressing the middle plate **200**, thereby minimizing the deformation of the middle plate **200** having a flat plate shape and minimizing the leakage of the refrigerant.

[0043] Hereinafter, the first leakage detection portion **210** according to the first embodiment of the present invention will be described in more detail with reference to FIGS. 4 and 5.

[0044] As illustrated in FIG. 4, in the first leakage detection portion **210** according to the first embodiment, the first leakage detection portion **210** may include a slit **211** formed to pass through an area between the fluid outlet hole **121** and the fluid inlet hole **122**. Accordingly, as illustrated in FIG. 5, when refrigerant leaks at a coupling portion between the fluid outlet hole **121** and the middle plate **200** as long as the flow of the normally flowing refrigerant is not obstructed, the uncooled refrigerant can be prevented from flowing into the fluid inlet hole along the surface of the middle plate **200**. That is, the leaked refrigerant may be discharged through the slit **211** along a contact surface of the middle plate **200** and the first housing **100**. Accordingly, the efficiency of the refrigerant manifold **1000** can be prevented from being lowered, and the leaked refrigerant can be discharged to the outside of the cooling channel, and thus it can be confirmed that leakage has occurred during leakage test.

[0045] In addition, the middle plate **200** may have through holes formed at positions corresponding to the bolt fastening portions, and the slits **211** may be formed to connect the through holes. Accordingly, when refrigerant leaks, the leaked refrigerant may smoothly move along the bolt fastened to the bolt fastening portion **123** toward the slit **211**, and it is possible to more clearly confirm that leakage has occurred during a refrigerant leakage test.

[0046] Hereinafter, the first leakage detection portion **210** according to the second embodiment of the present invention will be described in more detail with reference to FIGS. 6 and 7.

[0047] As illustrated in FIG. 6, in the first leakage detection portion **210** according to the first embodiment, the first leakage detection portion **210** may include a plate-shaped first cover **212** provided at a position corresponding to the fluid outlet hole **121** and coupled to the component mounting portion **120**, and a plate-shaped second cover **213** provided at a position corresponding to the fluid inlet hole **122** and coupled to the component mounting portion **120**, and the first cover **212** and the second cover **213** may be formed of separate components and provided at positions spaced a predetermined distance from each other.

[0048] Furthermore, in the present embodiment, the first leakage detection portion **210** may further include a plate-shaped third cover **214** that is formed as a component separately from the first cover **212** and the second cover **213**, provided at a position corresponding to the bolt fastening portion **123**, and coupled to the component mounting portion **120**. The third cover **214** may be formed integrally with the component mounting portion **120** or may be a flat plate attached to one surface of the component mounting portion **120**. A thickness of the third cover **214** may be greater than a thickness of the first cover **212** or the second cover **213** or may be formed to be greater than an average thickness of the middle plate **200**. By including the third cover **214**, it is easy to use a tool, such as a spanner, a socket wrench, or the like, to fasten the bolt fastened to the bolt fastening portion **123**, and the rigidity of a portion to which a fastening member is joined can be increased.

[0049] By applying the first leakage detection portion **210** according to the second embodiment, as illustrated in FIG. 7, when refrigerant leaks at the coupling portion of the fluid outlet hole **121** and the middle plate **200** as long as the flow of the normally flowing refrigerant is not obstructed, the uncooled refrigerant can be prevented from flowing into the fluid inlet hole along the surface of the middle plate **200**. That is, the leaked refrigerant may be discharged between the first cover **212** and the second cover **213** or between the first cover **212** and the second cover **213** and the third cover **214** along the contact surface of the middle plate **200** and the first housing **100**. Accordingly, the efficiency of the refrigerant manifold **1000** can be prevented from being lowered, and the leaked refrigerant can be discharged to the outside of the cooling channel, and thus it can be confirmed that leakage has occurred during leakage test.

[0050] Hereinafter, a basic configuration of the refrigerant manifold **1000** according to the second embodiment of the present invention will be described with reference to FIG. 8.

[0051] As illustrated in FIG. 8, the refrigerant manifold **1000** of the present invention may further include the first housing **100** in which the first refrigerant channel **110** is formed concavely on one surface thereof and the component mounting portion **120** on which a component is mounted is formed on the other surface, the middle plate **200** stacked on one surface of the first housing **100** to cover and block the first refrigerant channel **110**, and the second housing **300** in which a second refrigerant channel **310** is formed concavely on the other surface thereof and which is stacked on one surface of the middle plate **200**.

[0052] The second housing **300** is a component coupled to the middle plate **200** to form a refrigerant flow path through which refrigerant flows, the second refrigerant channel **310** may be formed concavely on the other surface of the second housing **300**, and the second housing **300** may include a refrigerant port connected to the second refrigerant channel **310**. The second housing **300** may be stacked on one surface of the middle plate **200** and joined by brazing. That is, the second housing **300** may be disposed at one side of the middle plate **200**, and the first housing **100** may be disposed at the other side. Accordingly, the refrigerant manifold **1000** of the present invention may form a more diverse refrigerant flow path using the second housing **300**. In addition, the second housing **300** may be formed to correspond to some areas of the middle plate **200**, and in this case, a part of the entire one surface of the remaining area of the middle plate **200** that does not correspond to the second housing **300** may be exposed to the outside.

[0053] In addition, the second housing **300** may include a second leakage detection portion **320**. The second leakage detection portion **320** may be formed at a position at which it is in contact with the second refrigerant channel **310** to discharge a fluid leaking from the second housing **300** to the

outside of a space formed by the second housing **300** and the middle plate **200**. By including the second leakage detection portion **320**, the refrigerant manifold **1000** according to the first embodiment of the present invention may discharge the leaked refrigerant to the outside through the second leakage detection portion **320** even when refrigerant leaks between the second housing **300** and the middle plate **200**, that is, therein, thereby more smoothly checking whether leakage occurs when a leakage test is performed on the refrigerant manifold **1000** of the present invention. [0054] Hereinafter, the second leakage detection portion **320** of the present invention will be described in more detail with reference to FIGS. **9** to **11**.

[0055] As illustrated in FIG. **9**, the second housing **300** may be formed with two or more refrigerant channels, each refrigerant channel may be formed to extend in the same direction and spaced a predetermined distance from each other, and the second leakage detection portion **320** may include a first leakage hole **321** formed between the second refrigerant channels **310**. In this case, two or more first leakage holes **321** may be formed in an extension direction of the refrigerant channel, and the number of first leakage holes **321** may be formed to a limit in which a durability problem does not occur considering materials and shapes of the second housing **300** and the middle plate **200**.

[0056] In addition, the second refrigerant channel **310** may include at least one bent portion at which the extension direction changes, and the first leakage hole **321** may be formed at a position at which it is in contact with the bent portion of the refrigerant channel. That is, when the second housing **300** is coupled to the middle plate **200**, the probability that compression does not occur completely is high, and thus by forming the first leakage hole **321** on the bent portion of the second refrigerant channel **310**, which is a portion with a high possibility of leakage, more accurate results can be derived during a refrigerant leakage test.

[0057] In addition, in one embodiment, as illustrated in FIG. **10**, the middle plate **200** may include a second leakage hole **215** formed to pass through a position corresponding to the first leakage hole **321**. Accordingly, the leaked refrigerant may be discharged more smoothly to the outside of the refrigerant manifold **1000**, thereby increasing the accuracy of the refrigerant leak test.

[0058] By applying the refrigerant manifold **1000** according to the second embodiment, as illustrated in FIG. **11**, when refrigerant leaks at an overlapping portion of the second cooling channel and the middle plate **200** as long as the flow of the normally flowing refrigerant is not obstructed, the uncooled refrigerant can be prevented from flowing into adjacent other second cooling channels along the surface of the middle plate **200**. That is, the leaked refrigerant may be discharged through the first leakage hole **321** and the second leakage hole **215** along the contact surface of the middle plate **200** and the first housing **100**. Accordingly, the efficiency of the refrigerant manifold **1000** can be prevented from being lowered, and the leaked refrigerant can be discharged to the outside of the cooling channel, and thus it can be confirmed that leakage has occurred during leakage test.

[0059] According to the refrigerant manifold according to the above configuration, by forming the hole or the slit in the middle plate and the housing of the parts to which the in/out ports are connected or the parts to which the in/out pipes are connected to discharge the leaked fluid to the outside when leakage occurs inside a manifold, it is possible to increase the accuracy of the leakage test.

[0060] The technical spirit of the present invention should not be construed as limited to the above-described embodiments. Not only the scope of applications is diverse, but also various modifications may be made by those skilled in the art without departing from the gist of the present invention as claimed in the claims. Therefore, these improvements and changes fall within the scope of the present invention as long as they are obvious to those skilled in the art.

DESCRIPTION OF REFERENCE NUMERALS

[0061] **1000**: refrigerant manifold [0062] **100**: first housing [0063] **110**: first cooling channel [0064] **120**: component mounting portion [0065] **121**: fluid outlet hole [0066] **122**: fluid inlet hole

[0067] **123**: bolt fastening portion [0068] **200**: middle plate [0069] **210**: first leakage detection portion [0070] **211**: slit [0071] **212**: first cover [0072] **213**: second cover [0073] **214**: third cover [0074] **215**: second leakage hole [0075] **300**: second housing [0076] **310**: second refrigerant channel [0077] **320**: second leakage detection portion [0078] **321**: first leakage hole [0079] **F1**: normally flowing fluid [0080] **F2**: leaked fluid

Claims

1. A refrigerant manifold comprising: a first housing in which a first refrigerant channel is formed on one surface thereof and a component mounting portion on which a component is mounted is formed on the other surface; and a middle plate stacked on one surface of the first housing to cover and block the first refrigerant channel, wherein the middle plate includes a first leakage detection portion formed at a position corresponding to the component mounting portion of the first housing to discharge a fluid leaking from the first housing to the outside of the first refrigerant channel.
2. The refrigerant manifold of claim 1, wherein the component mounting portion includes: a fluid outlet hole that transfers a fluid toward the component; and a fluid inlet hole that receives the fluid from the component and is formed at a position spaced a predetermined distance from the fluid outlet hole, and the first leakage detection portion includes a slit formed to pass through an area between the fluid outlet hole and the fluid inlet hole.
3. The refrigerant manifold of claim 2, wherein the component mounting portion includes a bolt fastening portion formed between the fluid outlet hole and the fluid inlet hole and including a hole or a groove into which a bolt is inserted to be fastened to the middle plate, the middle plate has each through hole formed at a position corresponding to the bolt fastening portion, and the slit is formed to connect the through holes.
4. The refrigerant manifold of claim 3, wherein the component mounting portion includes: the fluid outlet hole that transfers the fluid toward the component; the fluid inlet hole that receives the fluid from the component and is formed at a position spaced a predetermined distance from the fluid outlet hole, and a bolt fastening portion formed between the fluid outlet hole and the fluid inlet hole and including a hole or a groove into which a bolt is inserted to be fastened to the middle plate, the first leakage detection portion includes: a plate-shaped first cover provided at a position corresponding to the fluid outlet hole and coupled to the component mounting portion; and a plate-shaped second cover provided at a position corresponding to the fluid inlet hole and coupled to the component mounting portion, and the first cover and the second cover are formed of separate components and provided at positions spaced a predetermined distance from each other.
5. The refrigerant manifold of claim 4, wherein the first leakage detection portion further includes a plate-shaped third cover formed of a component separately from the first cover and the second cover, provided at a position corresponding to the bolt fastening portion, and coupled to the component mounting portion.
6. The refrigerant manifold of claim 5, wherein the third cover is a flat plate formed integrally with the component mounting portion or attached to one surface of the component mounting portion.
7. The refrigerant manifold of claim 5, wherein a thickness of the third cover is greater than a thickness of the first cover or the second cover.
8. The refrigerant manifold of claim 5, wherein a thickness of the third cover is greater than an average thickness of the middle plate.
9. A refrigerant manifold comprising: a first housing in which a first refrigerant channel is formed on one surface thereof and a component mounting portion on which a component is mounted is formed on the other surface; a middle plate stacked on one surface of the first housing to cover and block the first refrigerant channel; and a second housing in which a second refrigerant channel is formed on the other surface thereof and which is stacked on one surface of the middle plate, wherein the second housing includes a second leakage detection portion formed at a position at

which it is in contact with the second refrigerant channel to discharge a fluid leaking from the second housing to the outside of a space formed by the second housing and the middle plate.

10. The refrigerant manifold of claim 9, wherein the second refrigerant channel is formed as two or more second refrigerant channels in the second housing, the second refrigerant channels each extend in the same direction and are formed to be spaced a predetermined distance from each other, and the second leakage detection portion includes a first leakage hole formed between the second refrigerant channels.

11. The refrigerant manifold of claim 10, wherein the first leakage hole is formed as two or more first leakage holes in an extension direction of the second refrigerant channel.

12. The refrigerant manifold of claim 10, wherein the second refrigerant channel includes at least one bent portion at which the extension direction changes, and the first leakage hole is formed at a position at which it is in contact with the bent portion of the second refrigerant channel.

13. The refrigerant manifold of claim 10, wherein the middle plate includes a second leakage hole formed to pass therethrough at a position corresponding to the first leakage hole.
